

MAMA OF THE WHITE HOUSE

Four days before Mama was scheduled to work at the White House, we watched the Inaugural Parade. March 4, 1909, was a cold day, a snowy day. We had had one of the worst snow storms in Washington history, but fortunately it had stopped in time for the parade to be as large and as long as usual.

We stood on the curb on Pennsylvania Avenue— Mama and my brother Emmett and I— and watched Mrs. Taft ride by in a horse-drawn carriage with the President. I remember that she was wearing purple satin. I did not know it then, but Mrs. Taft was making history. This was the first time a President's wife rode from the Capitol swearing-in ceremony to the White House in the same carriage with her husband.

Later, I learned that eleven-year-old Charlie Taft, the youngest of the Taft children, had taken a copy of *Treasure Island* with him to read during the ceremony, so he wouldn't have to listen to his father's speech.

Mama told me about it one night after she'd gone to work for the Tafts, and I liked Charlie more because of it. I liked him still more when a pair of his knickerbocker

pants were brought home by Mama for Emmett to wear. Mrs. Taft had told Mama that they no longer fitted Charlie. Emmett and Charlie were the same size, though my brother was a year younger.

Charlie was not above taking off his shoes and wading in the fountain. Emmett, who had a White House job as yard boy, showed he was no sissy either when he played hooky from work, and ran off to the Washington Monument grounds to play baseball. It was his day of dire disgrace when Mr. Brown, his foreman, found him on the Monument grounds in back of the White House, and brought him back, all sand and grime, to Mama.

"I won't report it," Mr. Brown assured Mama. "We'll just give him another chance." Emmett hung his head and said nothing. He knew he'd have some explaining to do to Mama later.

Emmett grumbled to me about it. I was one year older and thus more sophisticated, so he could tell me things. If only Mama knew the things Charlie Taft got away with, he would complain, she'd *really* be surprised!

When his father was Secretary of War, Charlie had had the run of the White House with the children of Teddy Roosevelt, and they had enjoyed wonderful times. They had tied people's shoelaces together under the table. They had lured President Teddy up into the attic, and then turned the light out on him, and the President had almost had his eye poked out on a nail.

Oh, they had had some wild times!

So why was Mama all excited about Emmett's game of hooky? After all, he had finished picking up all the trash from Mrs. Taft's lawn party of the night before. But Mama didn't see it that way. She had gone to great pains to get him that job— she even had to obtain a special concession for him to work because he was only eleven.

Then there was the principle of the thing. Mama was a great one for principles.

"Emmett, never forget that this is the White House," she said. "It is the greatest honor that you can have to set foot here."

At this point, Emmett told me that the only thing that kept him from envying Charlie Taft was that Charlie had to wear a tuxedo to dine with the family. But he did envy him, he admitted, for having an automobile to ride in, even though Emmett had heard the President kid his son by telling him not to get too comfortable in the car, because it would be only a few years before they'd all be walking again.

"We only have a four-year lease on this car," President Taft said. It was the first horseless carriage to be used at the White House.

That was just over half a century ago. I see it all as if it were the day before yesterday— Mama and Emmett and I. Emmett grew to be six feet, two, and has spent a lifetime in military service. Today he is a Government guard, stationed at the San Diego Naval Base, and is looking forward to retirement.

Today, Mama is gone. But, as I now write, I am looking at her account, in her own handwriting, of how she took the job at the White House. Oh time, oh fate! Little did she know then that fifty-one years later I would be copying her description of that terrifying moment when she was to report for duty:

"March 8, 1909: Perhaps nothing ever again will be the same. I received word to report to the White House for duty. I arose early and dressed with care so that I might make a good appearance. While doing this, many thoughts raced through my mind. Would I please them? Was it wise for me to give up my trade, and to start where I was un-

known? I walked up and down about twenty minutes in front of the White House, trying to make up my mind whether to go in or not. Finally, I got enough courage to enter the large gate and go up the walk and enter the stately mansion. The door closed behind me. I was escorted to Major Brook's office, the Custodian. He in turn took me to Mrs. Jaffray, the housekeeper. And finally, I found myself, all humble and shaken, in front of the First Lady, herself. She had gentle eyes, and I felt less afraid. I noticed her lovely clothes and the violets she wore. Soon, I would learn that violets were her trademark."

If there is a heaven, and I meet Mama there, I know the first thing she will ask is, "Lillian, did you finish the job? Did you use my notes?" I could hardly face her if I didn't make use of the material she had spent a lifetime gathering.

Before Mama had gone to work at the White House, she had been a beautician. She made her visits to the homes of the wealthy, carrying her own little case of curling irons, lotions, and manicuring equipment.

She met my father, Emmett Rogers, who was the youngest headwaiter in Washington, and they were married. His work seemed to keep taking him away, and among my earliest memories, I was always on the go with him. Then Mama refused to travel so much, and he started going without us. He would send money from wherever he was, but Mama had to keep working to support Emmett and me.

When I was six, I had polio and was left with a crippled leg. I had to wear a heavy brace until I had an operation.

My last memory of my father is associated with the last time I ever saw him. I was nine years old, and Mama had just come to get us from our grandmother's in Virginia, and had taken us back to Washington. When we pulled into the station that evening, Father was there to greet us. Emmett and I had been staying with Grandmother, be-

cause there was no one to take care of us with both parents working. Some of the time, I had stayed at a Catholic school too, though I was an Episcopalian. So I wasn't very excited about traveling. I was glad to see Mama and Papa together. But then, they took us from the station to a friend's home and put us to bed. Mama said, "Kiss your father goodnight," and I saw tears in her eyes.

I did not know that when I awoke, he would be gone forever. He went to Kentucky to work, and he never returned. All I can remember of him are happy memories of childhood, when I made him laugh by putting my shoes on backward; standing between his legs as he sat at the table shaving; and peeping into the mirror with him.

My mother did not try to spoil my happy memories, and not until years later, did I learn that he had become an alcoholic and unable to hold a job. She had despaired of ever having a home for us. But when he was working, he was one of the best and highest-paid waiters. Mama never got a divorce, or had any interest in remarrying. She used to say that she never wanted a stepfather for her children. But it was a terrible life for us children, shuffling from relative to relative.

Then, one day, a friend of Mama's told her there would be an opening at the White House. Mama saw in it a chance for steady work, a chance to buy a house, and to keep us all together in a place where she could look after us herself. Half-frightened, half-thrilled, she got together the references that the White House requested. Evidently, she made the grade, because she had worked for many fine people in town, and was in much demand as a hairdresser.

She was called to the White House, and Col. Arthur Brooks, the custodian, asked her if she would be interested in the position of second maid. She said she would, and only a day or two went by before she was called to duty.

Housekeeper Elizabeth Jaffray must have been pleased with Mama's work as a beautician too, because one of Mama's duties was to give her a weekly manicure. Mrs. Jaffray, who was Mama's boss, was a very interesting woman. She had come from Canada, and she was very formal. She served as housekeeper at the White House for seventeen years. She lived at the White House, and her suite was on the same floor as that of the Presidential family in what we call the Center Blue Room, next to which was a small room that served as an office.

Every morning, the head of each department of the household staff would enter her office door and stand there formally, receiving orders, and discussing the coming activities of the day.

Every morning, she would put on her hat and veil and journey to the Center Market, using the carriage and horses of the White House. When everyone else was using automobiles, she refused to set foot in one, and continued using the carriage and horses.

Mrs. Taft always had Irish cooks. She preferred them. However, she brought in a special cook before State dinners to make the terrapin soup—and nothing else. I think the cook was given \$5 each time.

Mrs. Taft was very particular about the terrapin soup, and would always come to the kitchen to taste it, and make sure it had reached the peak of perfection. She was one of the few First Ladies who ever came into the kitchen. Mrs. Truman, years later, was another. Mama was always talking about Mrs. Taft and her terrapin soup, and outside, I would look at a turtle and be glad I didn't have to eat it.

Almost every night, Mama had a White House story for us. But there was one rule to the game. We were never to talk about anything Mama had told us outside of the house. Anything she told us was just for the three of us to enjoy, and if Emmett or I ever had repeated a story, that would

have been the end of the stories. So we never told, and we waited eagerly each night for Mama to come home and tell us of her wonderful adventures in the White House.

There were stories about eighteen-year-old Helen Taft, who was going to have her coming-out party in the White House, and Mama was very busy about that. Naturally, I lived it with Helen Taft—unknown to her, I'm sure. There was I, the little crippled girl in the gocart, living the thrilling life of "Miss Helen" at second hand, as told to me each night by Mama. We counted once, keeping track of how many nights in a row she had been invited out to dinner, and it was thirty-one consecutive times.

Inspired perhaps by her dazzling example, I determined that I too would walk some day without a brace, and even dance in a "Helen Pink" dress, when I grew up.

Then there were the hilarious stories about Mrs. Taft's troubles with the servants. She decreed that all waiters at the White House must have hair, and that no bald-headed butlers would be permitted in the dining room. She further ordered that all White House employees must be clean-shaven. Everyone shaved off their beards but one old man. He kept shortening it instead, but she would not settle for that, and eventually he had to shave off the whole thing.

Mama would keep us posted on the condition of his beard . . . shorter, shorter—gone.

There were stories about Mrs. Taft, and her outdoor parties, which were forever being rained out like a ball game. All the servants had to rush around and get everything under cover. Mama used to laugh and say that the good Lord must frown on outdoor parties at the White House, because He was forever sending rain.

Eventually, a little tent affair was set up, to help the First Lady fight the elements. Crowds would gather to watch the outdoor entertainment all around the White

House fence, and Mama said she felt like a monkey in a zoo. She hated to be conspicuous.

I hated to be conspicuous too, and I could have died the day I got caught in the White House by the President himself. We had moved into a house near the White House, and Mama was afraid to leave me alone when she went back to turn down the President's covers every evening at twilight. So she would sometimes take me with her.

She would arrange the bed linen, and leave me in the President's bedroom while she went to turn on the electric lights in the other family rooms. Turning on the lights was a momentous thing in those days, because electricity was still new, and there were servants in the White House who refused to touch the switches. Not for love nor money would they turn on electric lights, so Mama was the one who had that job.

"Don't you make a move, and don't touch the bed, and I'll be right back to get you," she would say as she hurried out.

One time, before she returned for me, a very stout man came into the room. I wasn't afraid of him, because he looked so big and jolly, and he beamed down at me. "Well, well, what have we here?" he said. "Are you the little ghost of the White House I've been hearing about?"

"No, I'm not a ghost," I assured him. "I'm Maggie's little girl, and I'm not supposed to be here."

The big, friendly man laughed. "Then let's pretend you're not here."

"All right," I said, relieved. "Just don't tell Mama you saw me."

So he didn't, and I didn't, and that was my first meeting with any President.

Mama brought home many ghost stories that were circulating around the White House, and once she told one

about a child in white who sounded a lot like me. I just kept quiet. I had been wearing white when I had my little talk with the President.

But the stories she told about the ghost of Abigail Adams walking through closed doors around the White House still got a rise out of me. Those I believed. And the ghost stories about the Presidents who still haunted the White House I believed too, but they didn't interest me. Mine was a feminine world.

Mama told me that several days a week, Mrs. Taft would talk to all kinds of ladies in the Red Room. All that any lady had to do was send a letter, and she could come. She would like to have a fire going in the fireplace if there was the slightest excuse for one, because it made the room look so good. Mama called it "holding court," and said that Mrs. Taft loved to sit in the firelight and "hold court."

Mama said that the servants were calling the White House "Malacañan Palace," because there is where the First Lady had lived once when her husband had been Governor of the Philippines, and she was trying to make the White House look the same. She brought in Oriental furniture, and Oriental tapestries, and floormats called *petates*. Huge Oriental screens stood in strategic places, and the maids were busy polishing teakwood.

To make the rooms look more like the Islands, Mrs. Taft, during her "reign," filled the White House to overflowing with greenery. She had plants and ferns and exotic flowers on every ledge and surface, and even in the fireplace. No one around the White House was more important than the horticulturist in those days. Mrs. Taft held long conversations with him on the house plants, their arrangement, their care, and their growth.

It was she who ordered the White House nursery men to round up all the Japanese cherry trees they could find, because she had loved them when she saw them in Japan.

This project of hers had such far-reaching results that it still influences Washington society today in the form of the Cherry Blossom Festival. But, at the time, the First Lady was only interested in copying the *luneta* in Manila, where public concerts were held in the park.

After the Japanese cherry trees had been planted, the Mayor of Tokyo received a report of it from the Japanese Embassy in Washington, and was so pleased that he sent a gift of 2,000 more Japanese cherry trees to the City of Washington.

Many readers will already know that the shipment had to be destroyed, because the trees were found to be diseased. But soon another batch arrived— 3,000 this time. The trees still flourish, and every spring they come alive in glorious color, and form an excuse for the cherry blossom extravaganza that Mrs. Taft would have loved— the selection of a queen to reign over the congregation of dignitaries, and tourists from every state of the Union. Probably Mrs. Taft herself would have picked the queen. She loved pageantry.

As it turned out, the First Lady was a sensation at the opening of Washington's version of the *luneta*. About 10,000 people showed up to watch Mrs. Taft tour up and down the Potomac Drive, and greet her friends in a Landaulette motor car, to the strains of the Marine Band. The concerts continued to be held on Wednesdays and Saturdays, from 5:00 until 7:00, for many years.

One night, the "White House bedtime story" had special significance, because, seated on Mama's lap as she told it, was a kitten that had followed her home from the White House. Mama had worked late that evening, because Admiral Togo of Japan had arrived, and so what could be more appropriate than that we name the kitten "Admiral Togo"?

Not so long after that, the "Admiral" surprised us by marching into the house with a retinue of four kittens, which he— she— had brought out of hiding. Mama didn't want to change the Admiral's name. She said we'd just let her be the first female admiral.

How wonderful those days were! We loved the little house we lived in, and the exciting White House life we shared in a strange way.

One of my favorite stories, which Mama brought home, was how the President and First Lady had met. It was at a coasting party when he was a law student in Cincinnati. He had offered her a ride on his sled.

Mama said that when the First Lady told this story to friends, the President would add, with a wink, "And Nellie and I have been sliding downhill ever since." Her name was Helen, but he called her "Nellie." Mrs. Taft would tell him to behave, or she would tell how he had played "Sleeping Beauty" at his men's club show.

Easter Mondays, Emmett and I would go to roll eggs on the White House lawn, and a neighbor would take us, because we had to be with an adult. Mama would come out on the roof to wave to us. I would be so proud in my "Helen Pink" dress as I waved back, and all the people would look on curiously.

It was a big day when I was invited to lunch with Mama at the White House and take my grandmother sightseeing. A storm came up, and as we crossed Pennsylvania Avenue, I got thoroughly splashed by a passing car. When I got inside, Mama was so shocked, that she took me to the laundry room and washed and ironed my dress before I could have a bite of food or see the White House with Grandmother. Mama said I would disgrace her if I went through the house sight-seeing like that.

I didn't know that eventually I would be working in those very rooms where Mama got me cleaned and primped

for my visit. I remember standing and looking in curiously through the sewing room door.

In the summer, the First Family would move to Beverly, Massachusetts, and open up the summer White House. Mrs. Taft would take the first and third maid, the first and third cook and the head and third butler. Mama, the second maid, was left to take care of the President and his guests. The second butler and the second cook would also stay in Washington, and the President would remain at work until Congress adjourned. He would take week-end trips to be with his family.

The President had a strange habit of falling asleep when the First Lady was not there to keep after him. The butler was afraid to disturb him, and would leave the last few courses right on the table rather than wake him. The butler had an agreement with the doorman to finish the job, since the doorman would be the last one to leave.

Mama never got to see much of son Robert, who would one day almost receive the nomination for the Presidency. He was already at Yale when she went to work for the Tafts.

Just once, Mama got to travel with Mrs. Taft. She went to Hot Springs, Virginia, with the First Lady, and they stayed for nine days. Part of the time that she was at the White House, she was a personal maid to the First Lady.

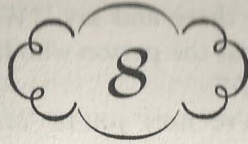
The White House had quite an effect on Mama. She wanted everything in our house to be as elegant as possible, and, as she saved enough money, she would buy additional pieces of furniture. These additions may have come from the second-hand store, but they were always in such good taste, that they looked as if they might have come from that wonderful White House— at least to my eye.

Our yard too was so pretty and full of flowers, that people walking by would stop to look. Mama would laugh when

she'd see them out there and say, "Wouldn't they really stare if they knew that the person who lives here is 'Maggie of the White House.'"

I said, "No, you're not; you're 'Mama of the White House.'"

And so she was to me.



MRS. TAFT AND HER JINX

Little by little, Mama became convinced that a jinx was following Mrs. Taft around. True, it was great luck that she was in the White House and all that. However, everything was always so complicated for her— like the first batch of Japanese cherry trees that embarrassed Mrs. Taft no end.

Mama claimed that the jinx must have arrived at the White House with Mrs. Taft on the very day of the inauguration. It wasn't only that the weather had broken all records for nastiness— freezing cold and nine inches of snow in March— but there was the matter of the missing inaugural gown.

When Mama went to work at the White House, the help was still discussing Mrs. Taft's close call with the dress she wore to her Inaugural Ball. The dress was being made in New York, and was to be hand-delivered to the White House. Transportation was disrupted by the storm, and the messenger had not arrived. Mrs. Taft was frantic. To make matters worse, instead of sympathizing with her, the President calmly sat down and took a nap.

Finally it was time for Mrs. Taft to start dressing, and

she picked out a substitute dress. Her maid was so upset waiting for the gown, that she put up Mrs. Taft's hair three times, trying to get it right for the ball. She was about to try a fourth time, but Mrs. Taft thought that would be bad luck, and started putting on the old gown, feeling that she was not looking her best.

Then the messenger arrived with the dress— white satin embroidered with goldenrods— but it was too late to make Mrs. Taft feel relaxed and happy, as she should have been on this occasion.

It just wasn't her day. Before she had gone to the Capitol, she had had a bit of bad luck with another garment— the aigrette feather on her hat had gotten singed, and it had to be cut almost in half to make it look right.

There was all the gossip about whether Mrs. Taft had pushed her husband into the Presidency. Other servants told Mama that they had heard President Teddy Roosevelt discuss the fact that Mrs. Taft had asked him not to appoint her husband to the Supreme Court, because it would ruin his chances for the Presidency. And they had heard Teddy Roosevelt assure her that her husband was his personal choice as his successor. She had even come to the White House secretly to ask the President not to appoint her husband to the vacancy on the Supreme Court, the third which occurred during his administration.

The servants all said there were no White House secrets under Teddy Roosevelt, because he talked so loud and never closed a door. But Mrs. Taft knew people were talking about her part in her husband's career, and she was hurt because it made her sound "pushy."

To add to the evidence, the servants heard President Taft tell Mrs. Taft, while she was nervous and upset about the missing dress, "Well, now I'm in the White House, and I'm not going to be pushed any more."

And he wasn't. His solution to problems seemed to be to turn on a Caruso record good and loud and fall asleep.

Her problems grew more tense and so did the help. When she was worried, Mrs. Taft would get intensely interested in housekeeping. You could hardly turn around in the kitchens or on the stairs of the White House without running into Mrs. "T." She checked up on everybody to see if the pots and pans were smiling, the glasses sparkled, all the cushions were plumped up, and the floors were shiny. She ran her fingers along things to find dust; when she wanted to, she found it.

Mama felt sorry for her, because she understood it was just her nerves. Mama's own day at the White House was pretty busy too. She began by washing down the grand staircase every morning before breakfast, so Mama knew all about nerves.

Mrs. Taft seemed to feel responsible for everything—her household and her husband's success. The first thing that the household staff noticed upon her arrival as First Lady was that she sat in on her husband's important conferences. None of the old-timers had ever seen this before in previous administrations. Mrs. Taft also entered into political discussions at White House parties with the men who surrounded her husband, and seemed to enjoy that more than talking with the ladies.

It didn't help her popularity to mix into "men's business" though, and then the jinx paid another visit in the matter of a "harmless" letter. It was merely a letter from some women in the Balkan States who had formed an organization for political and social reform work in their country. They suggested that she form a similar organization in the United States.

Mrs. Taft sent a friendly letter, declining the proposition, but somehow they took it to mean that she was encouraging the ladies in their work. American papers

claimed that she was "meddling" in international affairs, and it became an international situation in which our State Department had to exchange diplomatic notes with the Balkan government to get it all straightened out.

Mrs. Taft naturally felt very upset, because she had not meant to start an international incident, and Mama felt very sorry for her. "It is hard for a First Lady to say anything that will not be misunderstood," Mama told me.

Taft was the first President to receive a salary of \$75,000, and Mrs. Taft seemed to feel that this called for her to make a display of economy in order to show she wasn't affected by it. Mama felt that the First Lady was trying too hard to set a good example for the ladies of the United States, because she did it by keeping a cow right on the White House grounds. Of course, everyone was shocked, even the White House staff, who were used to many innovations, but hadn't seen a cow around since the days of Andrew Johnson, ten Presidents before.

Mama and all the rest of the staff called the cow "Mooly-Wooly." In strange contrast to the cow, there was a white poodle, who gave the White House a very fashionable air. Poor Mrs. Taft had to take some ribbing about her "economical" cow, but she stood fast and even changed Mooly-Wooly for another cow, who gave more milk.

She also took some other steps in her economy drive. Mrs. Taft ordered all foods bought in wholesale lots, to obtain them more cheaply, and laid down the rule that out-of-season food would not be served at the White House.

Meanwhile, Mama had her own economy problems, and took her own steps toward their solution. Whenever there was a reception, she took the wraps in the cloakroom. She did not get overtime for working at social functions, but received tips from the guests, and this helped pad out the \$20-a-month salary.

At Christmas, everyone who worked at the White House would receive a turkey and cranberries to take home. When they were passing out the turkeys, they would always say, "Give Maggie the biggest one, because she has two young ones." In our little house, we made that turkey last as long as possible.

Though I was listening to many gay and happy stories of the White House, Mama also told me how tension mounted on tension. Once, a U.S. Senator who had been invited to dinner, did not show up, and didn't even send his regrets before— or after— the dinner. Mrs. Taft took it badly.

It was no wonder that not too long after she had arrived at the White House, the First Lady suffered a stroke, and had to be in bed for some time. The incident revealed to us all the depth of the President's love for his wife. He sat with her for hours, reading to her, and helping her practice to regain her speech. He was tenderness itself, and he didn't fall asleep.

He would always try to make her laugh. He would bring her flowers from the White House gardens and say, "I stole these for you." This running gag began when he picked the flowers for the first time— he was discovered by the gardener, who thought he was a thief.

As soon as Mrs. Taft was well enough, the President was up to his old tricks again, even falling asleep over his dinner. She was back at his political conferences too. But Mama understood why. It was to protect her husband from ridicule over his sleeping habits.

Backstairs, the servants knew that she was trying to keep the President awake by prodding him when she saw him drifting off— something that no one else would dare do. They felt sorry for her. Sometimes she would carry on the conversation for him, for she was a brilliant woman, and she did know his views.

He fell asleep at the most peculiar times, even once at a funeral. Guests would be embarrassed when he would fall asleep in the middle of their stories, and poor Mrs. Taft would have to cover for him.

Sometimes, when they were alone, she would scold him for this bad habit, and would bring up the fact that in Manila, when she needed him most during a typhoon, he had gone to sleep in a chair, leaving her alone to cope with the terrified family and staff. "The chair was shaking— how could you sleep?" she would ask him.

"Now, Nellie, you know it is just my way," he would reply. "I knew you could handle it."

About the only time he wouldn't fall asleep was when he was talking to a pretty girl, and those were the times when Mrs. Taft wished he would. Backstairs, the help joked about the way the President loved to talk to pretty women. He would bore them to death with his long legal explanations, and they would try to look bright and interested. Whenever the President singled out the most beautiful woman at any party, Mrs. Taft, always the perfect lady on the surface, did not fool the staff, who knew she was boiling inside.

Taft had trouble with time too, and seldom kept an appointment at the specified hour. He would stash different callers in different rooms, and forget which room to go to next. It was fortunate that he had Mrs. Taft as his "helper without portfolio."

Mama said that the people did not realize the importance of Mrs. Taft's diligence and absolute dedication. She stood up at receptions again, and wore herself out at them. Her only concession to health was to wear low heels, which further distressed her, because she was style-conscious and dressed beautifully.

She was also weight-conscious— especially her husband's

weight— and somehow she seemed to feel she was responsible for the fact that he weighed a horrible 322 pounds.

Mama copied and brought home a poem that was making the rounds among the domestics; it was on the subject of the President's bulk. It had come to the White House by way of guests, who said it dated from the days of Malacañan Palace:

"As butterflies fly sipping,
There's a waltzer who is ripping.
'Tis a sight to see Taft tripping
On the light, fantastic toe."

On this score— his weight— even the President was self-conscious. The nation thought that Taft was not at all sensitive about his poundage, but he really was.

A special bathtub had to be installed in the White House, because he would get stuck in a normal tub, and it would take two men to pull him out. When the newspapers made much of the rumor that he needed a special bathtub to hold his 322 pounds, he tried to deny it, but it was true just the same.

I have a picture of that bathtub, with four workmen, fully dressed, sitting in it, but the President hated to think that the country knew he was too fat to sit in a normal tub.

He talked about it in Provincetown, Massachusetts, in August of 1910, when he dedicated the monument that marked the place where the Pilgrims had first set foot in this country. He said, "There are certain stories that I'd like to deny. We have no special bathtubs made for any Executive of any particular size." As the crowd laughed, he added that he too had arrived in a ship named the *Mayflower*, and he brought more laughter and applause when he ended with the punch line, "It did not happen

from any particular arrangement, only that the vessel was the most suitable, leaving out the question of bathtubs."

The little meal he enjoyed that day consisted merely of lobster stew, salmon cutlets with peas, cold roast tenderloin with vegetable salad, roast turkey with potato salad, cold tongue and ham, frozen pudding, cake, fruit, and coffee. It did tend to put on weight.

Mrs. Taft worried constantly about his weight, and at first, wondered why the diets she put him on did no good. But we *knew* why.

The President could eat everything and anything— and he did. He had pains in his toes, and Mrs. Taft told him that this meant the gout, but he denied it, and refused to see a doctor. When he finally did see a doctor, that was what he had, and he was placed on a strict diet.

Mrs. Taft hovered over him, and supervised the diet at the White House, but the President was not always at home. When he didn't lose weight, and didn't lose weight, she found out that he was gorging himself elsewhere. Any time he went on his private train, he would have it well-stocked with all the foods he wasn't supposed to eat. All his friends seemed to cooperate with *him* in beating his diet, rather than with *her* in keeping him on his diet.

The person for whom the staff felt sorriest was Helen, who was at that painful college age when it hurt to have a daddy whom people said looked like Santa Claus.

Mama and the other maids felt the shadow of Mrs. Taft's jinx too. Every outdoor party was marred by some act of fate, including stinging mosquitos and flies that flew into the punch.

Mrs. Taft's favorite cook married suddenly, and Mrs. Taft took it as a personal blow dealt by the same unrelenting fate. No cook would stay. No wonder: the President was forever keeping the kitchen off balance by bringing any number of guests home with him without advance

warning. This, coupled with Mrs. Taft's habit of looking into their pots and pans, made them decide that the honor of working in the White House wasn't worth the strain on their nervous systems.

Even the cooks who cooked for the help wouldn't stay. Mama once filled in, in an emergency, and the servants complained that she cooked "scrambled food."

Finally, Mrs. Taft became so desperate, that she lured back the cook, who had left to get married. But the jinx struck again—it was discovered that the cook's husband had TB. Then the situation became further complicated by the cook's baby, and Mrs. Taft even had to arrange for the care of the baby so its mother could cook at the White House.

I asked Mama if Mrs. Taft's jinx had gone along to the Malacañan Palace, and Mama said, "Of course. It travels everywhere." Mrs. Taft had told her that almost upon her arrival, there had been such a terrible tropical storm, that the palace entrance hall had been inundated under several feet of water.

And once in London, traveling with her children, when she was the wife of the Secretary of War, she lost her luggage, and the boat train was held up until they could find it. Her credentials got her nowhere, and the only way in which she was able to hold the train was to explain that she was the wife of "the man who is travelling with Miss Alice Roosevelt." Even in London, they had heard about that much-publicized official junket of the President's daughter, and a Congressional committee, to the Philippines.

Although Mrs. Taft often told this story, always with a genteel laugh, Mama always felt that the First Lady was envious of Alice Roosevelt Longworth, the young matron who continued to hold the public's attention and affection, even throughout Taft's administration.

And, another time, when she went to Cuba to join her

husband, hadn't the jinx gone right along? A rebellion broke out, and she needed the Marines to protect her. "But," she used to add proudly, "as a result, I was mistress of the palace at Havana for three days."

There was no doubt about it, the First Lady would have made a happy queen, had the Americans chosen a monarchy. The servants agreed on that. They would look at Mrs. Taft's treasured photos of herself in native Philippine dress, and chuckle, trying to imitate her voice: "They don't do things at the White House the way we used to do them at the Malacañan Palace."

But if she didn't succeed, it wasn't for not trying. She decreed that all the staff would have fancy uniforms, and the houseboys were to wear full-dress uniforms while they worked. They were saved from this fate when one boy said to another in her hearing, "Won't we look fine cleaning windows in tails?" They heard no more about it.

Then there was the tragedy of Captain Archie Butt. He was the military aide appointed by Teddy Roosevelt, and was one of President Taft's closest friends. He spent much of his time at the White House and frequently stayed overnight, because his conferences with the President would last so late. Eventually, the strain made him ill, and he went to Italy for his health.

He had a strange premonition before he left. Mama knew about his feeling, because he told her, "Maggie, I can't sleep. I feel so restless. Something is hanging over me." Mama moved him from room to room to try to get him to rest, because he was then staying at the White House.

He even quit teasing Alice, the second cook. Alice specialized in making waffles and griddle cakes, and waffles were Captain Butt's favorite food. No matter how many times he would pass the kitchen on the way to the President's office, he would put his head in the door and call

to Alice, "Say, Alice, when are we going to have some waffles?"

Alice had a stock answer. She always replied, "Tomorrow," even though he had just finished eating some.

But suddenly he wasn't even interested in waffles or teasing Alice any more. Captain Butt went to Italy and never returned. On his way back to the States, he went down with the *Titanic*, in April, 1912.

The jinx seemed to have affected the President's disposition too. He had practically lived at the White House when Teddy Roosevelt was there. He came to lunch almost every day, and was welcomed by the servants as the best-tempered man they knew. Now, as President, they classified him as a "sourpuss."

The public also grumbled, saying that as a President, Taft would make a better judge. He spent so much time deliberating, that he never got around to action till the crisis was over, and he became known as a "do nothing" President.

He was the first golfing President, and his administration was ideally suited to the growth of private enterprise and individual initiative. The only *unpleasant* thing that happened was the 16th Amendment, which meant that everyone would have to pay an income tax, and *no one was happy over that!*

When it was time for the nominations again, the special Taft jinx really struck when the former President, Teddy Roosevelt, actually ran against the man he had hand-picked to succeed him. That was really bad luck.

When I grew older, I asked Mama why President Roosevelt had turned against President Taft, and why they hadn't even ridden together in the same car that inauguration day in 1909. Mama said that all the help had agreed that President Roosevelt owed favors to various people and had wanted President Taft to promise to ap-

point these people to his Cabinet, which he wouldn't do.

President Roosevelt took this failure of Taft's to do his bidding for ingratitude, and once started downhill, the friendship fell apart. Half the servants were for Taft; half were for T.R.; but they were careful that the family heard no part of their arguments.

Mother was definitely on the side of Taft, and she thought it shocking that a man would relinquish an office without a fight, and then, four years later, try to regain it from his successor, especially since they had once been friends. The servants had taken sides on that issue too—did T.R. have the right to be angry with Taft?

Half the staff thought that Taft had erred and deserved the enmity of T.R., because "a promise is a promise, and must be kept," but again Mama was loyal to her boss, and she claimed a President was chosen to lead the people, because the public had faith in him. Therefore, they wanted his choice of officials, and not the choice of someone else whom they had not elected.

Mrs. Taft was sure that her husband would win in his fight for re-election. She was so indignant when she saw critical stories about her husband during the Presidential race, that she stopped reading the newspapers.

Mama was very sad when Taft failed to make it, and Woodrow Wilson, a Democrat, won out over the Republican party and the Bull Moose, Teddy Roosevelt. Still, she remembered that her duty lay with the White House, no matter who was in it, and that carried her through the bleak days when she was helping an embittered Mrs. Taft to pack up.

When it came time to go, Mrs. Taft left the White House without saying good-by to Mama, and Mama was hurt, because she had grown so fond of the First Lady. She couldn't believe that Mrs. Taft would fail to say good-by to her. But Mama felt better when she found out that she

was not the only one who hadn't received a personal farewell.

One day, years later, when I was inspecting the packages and cameras of the tourists as they came through the White House, I noticed a pretty blonde girl who came in alone. She was about fifteen or sixteen, I think. She didn't hurry on with the rest, but lagged behind, looking around. Finally she said wistfully, "I wish I could see more. I'd like to see the parlor, because my grandfather was here once."

I thought her grandfather might have been a guest at some time, and I asked who he was.

"President Taft," she said.

"What is your father's name?" I asked.

"Charlie Taft," she said.

I thought of the little boy who had waded in the fountain, who had grabbed phones when he shouldn't have, who had held long discussions with reporters, and whose pants had been worn by my brother.

Charlie Taft's daughter was escorted through the whole White House. As I walked with this sedate little girl, I thought of how unlike her father she seemed to be, and I remembered the Charlie Taft whom Mama and Emmett knew, the Charlie Taft who had tied shoe laces together under the table, and who bragged how he had helped Quentin Roosevelt stick spitballs that looked like warts on a picture of Andy Jackson that hung in the White House.

It was hard to realize that the mischievous little boy, who had made White House history for me, was now the dignified father of this dignified little girl. Somehow I wished she could have known the other Charlie too.

I don't know how you feel about jinxes, but even after

Mrs. Taft left, her jinx seemed to remain with the bed she had slept in.

Mrs. Taft had been the first President's wife to introduce twin beds in the White House. It was on one of these that she suffered such a breakdown of health, that she even lost her power of speech. It was on this bed that the next First Lady, Ellen Louise Wilson, died. It was on this bed that Coolidge's son lay in pain with blood poisoning before he was carried to the hospital to die. And it was on this bed that Mrs. Harding would lie at death's door.

The happy ending to this chapter belongs to President Taft himself. He finally got what he really wanted all along— a seat on the Supreme Court. He was Chief Justice for nine blissful years, from 1921 to 1930. Mama said Mrs. Taft's jinx was non-transferable *out* of the White House.